FORGE

PHASE 2 — DEVELOPMENT

Week 17 of 36

Simulation Training Block 1a

Sessions 49–51

Week 17: Simulation Training Block 1a

Facilitator Notes for Week 17

Week 17 starts simulation training, where the whole toolkit gets used under pressure: the conflict resolution model, de-escalation, communication, boundaries and the MI skills from Week 16. Most programs talk about what to do. Here the men do it, in front of the people they live with, so that in a real dorm situation they respond with skill instead of instinct. Session 49 teaches the six-step format (scene set, first attempt, freeze and feedback, replay, debrief, lessons learned), the observer roles, the scoring rubric and the five safety agreements, and the room changes to a stage with observers in a semicircle. Sessions 50 and 51 run the first two scenarios: a property dispute heading toward threats, and a man labeled a snitch who wants the mentor to clear his name. Every mistake made here is one not made with someone's safety at stake. Keep telling the men that this block is practice; graded simulations come in Week 23. And hold each freeze to one or two coaching points.

What to Watch For

Performance anxiety: The first simulation session will be nerve-wracking for most participants. Normalize the anxiety. The participants who are most anxious often take the process most seriously.

Natural ability vs. effort: Some participants will be naturals — calm under pressure, good instincts. Others will struggle. Both need coaching. The naturals may need to be pushed to use specific techniques instead of relying on charm. The struggling participants need encouragement and specific, actionable feedback.

Group dynamics during feedback: Watch for feedback that's competitive rather than supportive. "I would have done it better" is not helpful. "Here's what I noticed and what I might try" is. Correct this early — it sets the tone for all remaining simulations.

Role-player intensity: Brief your role-players before each simulation. They should be realistic but not cruel. The goal is to test the mentor, not to break them. If a role-player goes too far, call "Freeze" and redirect.

Who's avoiding the hot seat: By the end of Week 17, every participant should have been in the mentor role at least once. If someone is consistently finding ways to avoid it, address it directly and privately: "I notice you haven't volunteered. You're up next session. I'll make sure you're ready."

Common Week 17 Challenges

"I froze." Normal. "Freezing is your brain recognizing that it doesn't have a practiced response for this situation yet. That's exactly why we're doing this. The more you practice, the less you freeze."

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"It doesn't feel real." Fair point. "It's not real — and it doesn't need to be. It needs to be realistic enough to trigger the same thinking and emotional responses. If your heart rate went up, if you felt pressure, if you had to make decisions in real time — the simulation is working."

"The role-player went too hard on me." Address this with the role-player privately. But also coach the mentor: "In real life, people don't follow a script. They'll say things that surprise you. Part of what we're training is your ability to handle the unexpected."

The competitive mentor: Some participants will try to show off during simulations — performing for the group rather than practicing skills. Coach them privately: "I can see you have confidence. What I need from you is depth, not performance. Show me the skills, not the style."

Preparation for Week 17

- Review the Simulation Training format in the Program Design (Part III)
- Prepare scenario cards for Simulation 1 (Property Dispute) and the Introduction to Simulations session
- Set up the room for simulations — clear a space for the "stage" area
- Review the scoring rubric — be prepared to explain it clearly
- Prepare observer role cards (what to watch for during simulations)
- Have extra scenario copies for role-players
- If Senior Mentors are available, brief them on their role during simulations (they may play scenario characters)

Week 17 Overview

Purpose: Introduce simulation training — FORGE's core innovation — and begin the first block of dorm conflict simulations. By the end of this week, every participant should understand how simulations work, be comfortable with the freeze-and-coach process, and have completed their first two dorm conflict simulations.

Context: Participants now have a full toolkit: cognitive restructuring, emotional regulation, conflict resolution, communication, de-escalation, teaching, facilitation, and Motivational Interviewing. Simulation training is where all those skills get tested under pressure. This is not a test — it's practice. The goal is to build muscle memory so that when real situations arise, participants respond with skill instead of instinct.

Sessions This Week:

- Session 49: Introduction to Simulations
- Session 50: Simulation 1 — Property Dispute Escalating to Threats
- Session 51: Simulation 2 — Gossip and Reputation Damage

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Materials Needed:

- Simulation Scoring Rubric (1 per participant + extras for observers)
- Observer Role cards (1 per observer — template below)
- Scenario cards for Simulations 1 and 2 (role-player copies and mentor copies)
- Lessons Learned sheets (blank, 1 per participant per simulation)
- Journals/notebooks
- Easel paper or whiteboard for debrief notes
- Timer or watch for scene timing

Room Setup Note: Starting this week, arrange the room differently. Clear a space in the center or at one end for the "stage" — where simulations happen. Remaining chairs form a semicircle around the stage for observers. This setup will be used for all simulation sessions.

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SESSION 49: Introduction to Simulations

Duration: 2 hours
Session Number: 49
Facilitator(s): Program Lead + Senior Mentor (if available)

Learning Objectives

By the end of this session, participants will be able to:

1. Explain why simulation training is effective and how it builds skills differently than discussion
2. Describe the simulation format: scene set, first attempt, freeze and coach, replay, debrief
3. Demonstrate the "freeze and coach" technique
4. Describe observer roles and what to watch for during a simulation
5. Articulate the psychological safety agreements for simulation training
6. Understand the simulation scoring rubric (6 criteria, 1-4 scale)

Session 49 Checklist

- ☐ Room set up with stage area and observer semicircle
- ☐ Opening circle completed — "Wished you'd practiced beforehand?"
- ☐ Why simulation training works — explained with firefighter analogy
- ☐ Six-step simulation format taught (scene set, attempt, freeze/coach, replay, debrief, document)
- ☐ Freeze and coach demonstration completed with volunteers
- ☐ Observer roles explained (6 categories)
- ☐ Scoring rubric distributed and walked through
- ☐ Psychological safety agreements discussed and committed to
- ☐ Next session's simulation previewed (property dispute)
- ☐ Closing circle completed
- ☐ Homework assigned (think through property dispute scenario + journal)

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Session Plan

Opening Circle (10 minutes)

> **Facilitator:**
>
> *"Check-in round. How are you doing? And this question:* ***Have you ever had to deal with a real situation in the dorm where you wished you'd practiced beforehand — where you had to figure it out in the moment with no preparation?****"*

Send the talking piece. Most people will have stories. That's the setup — simulations exist so you don't have to figure it out cold.

Why Simulation Training Works (15 minutes)

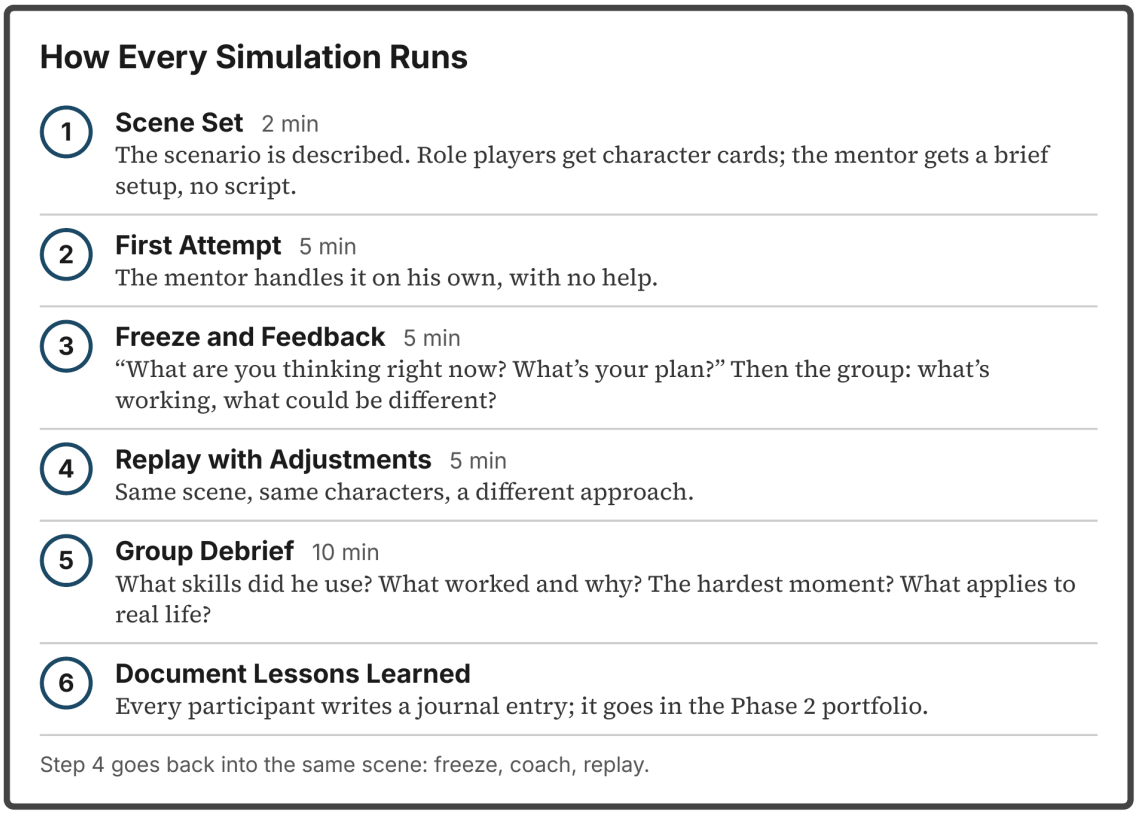
> **Facilitator:**
>
> *"Starting today, we're entering the part of FORGE that separates this program from almost every other program in the state. Simulation training.*
>
> *Most programs talk about what to do. FORGE makes you do it.*
>
> *Think about it this way. If you were training to be a firefighter, would you sit in a classroom for six months reading about fire and then get sent into a burning building? No. You'd practice. In controlled conditions. With experienced people coaching you. Over and over until your body knows what to do before your brain has to think about it.*
>
> *That's what simulations are. You're going to practice responding to the exact situations you'll face as a FORGE mentor — dorm conflicts, resistant mentees, safety situations, crisis moments. You'll do it in front of this group, with coaching, with feedback, with the chance to try again.*
>
> *Here's what the research says: people who practice skills through simulation retain them at roughly double the rate of people who only discuss them. When the pressure is on, your body goes to what it's practiced, not what it's read. We're training your reflexes."*
>
> *"I want to be straight with you about something: simulations are uncomfortable. You're going to stand up in front of this group and respond to a scenario in real time. You're going to make mistakes. You're going to freeze. You're going to say the wrong thing. And every person in this room is going to see it.*
>
> *That sounds brutal. But here's the truth:* ***every mistake you make in a simulation is a mistake you don't make in real life.*** *In real life, the stakes are someone's safety. In here, the stakes are your pride. I'd rather you bruise your pride now than fail someone later."*

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How Simulations Work (20 minutes)

> **Facilitator:**
>
> *"Every simulation follows the same format. Learn this — it won't change."*

Write or display each step:



The six steps of every simulation, as written or displayed.

> ***Step 1: Scene Set (2 minutes)***
>
> *"I describe the scenario. Who's involved, what's happening, what the mentor walks into. Role-players get their character cards — they know their motivation, their mood, their lines. The mentor gets a brief setup: Here's what you know. Here's what you don't. Go.*
>
> *The mentor doesn't get time to prepare a script. That's intentional. Real life doesn't give you a script."*
>
> ***Step 2: First Attempt (5 minutes)***
>
> *"The simulation begins. The mentor walks into the situation and responds however they respond. Role-players stay in character. The scene plays out in real time.*
>
> *During the first attempt, the mentor is on their own. No help. This shows us your natural instincts — what you default to under pressure. Your defaults are important information."*

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Step 3: Freeze and Feedback (5 minutes)

"At some point during the first attempt — or at the end of 5 minutes — I call 'Freeze.' Everyone stops. I turn to the mentor and ask: 'What are you thinking right now? What's your plan? What do you need?'

Then I open it up to the group: 'What's working? What could be different? What would you try?'

This is not a pile-on. This is coaching. The feedback should be specific and actionable. Not 'You should have done better' — that's useless. Instead: 'When he raised his voice, your body tensed up. Try dropping your shoulders and slowing your voice next time. Match his energy with calm, not with tension.'"

Step 4: Replay with Adjustments (5 minutes)

"The mentor goes back into the scene and tries again, incorporating the coaching. Same scenario, same characters — but different approach. This is where the real learning happens. You get to feel the difference between your first instinct and a coached response.

Sometimes the replay goes better. Sometimes it doesn't. Both are valuable."

Step 5: Group Debrief (10 minutes)

"After the replay, we all sit down and break it down:

- *What skills did the mentor use?*
- *What worked and why?*
- *What was the hardest moment?*
- *What would we do differently?*
- *What did we learn that applies to real life?*

Every person in the room learns from every simulation — not just the person in the hot seat. Observers often learn more than participants because they can see the dynamics clearly."

Step 6: Document Lessons Learned

"After each simulation, every participant writes a brief lessons learned entry in their journal. What did you observe? What would you take into a real situation? This becomes part of your Phase 2 portfolio."

The Freeze and Coach Technique — Demonstration (15 minutes)

Facilitator:

"Let me show you how freeze and coach works. I need two volunteers. One of you is going to play a mentor. The other is going to play a dorm member who's angry because someone moved his stuff off a shelf.

This is not a graded simulation. This is a demonstration. The point is to see the format, not to perform perfectly."

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Set up a simple scenario:

> *"Here's the scene: You walk into the common area and a man is standing over his belongings, which have been moved off the shelf and piled on the floor. He's loud. He's angry. He's saying, 'Whoever did this is going to hear from me.' A couple of other men are watching. You're a FORGE mentor in this dorm. Go."*

Let the scene run for 2 minutes. Then call "Freeze."

> **Facilitator:**
> *"[Mentor's name] — freeze right there. Don't move. What's going through your head right now?"*

Let the mentor respond.

> *"Good. Group — what's working so far? What would you adjust?"*

Take 2-3 suggestions. Pick one and tell the mentor: "Try that. Same scene. Go."

Run the replay for 2 minutes. Then call "Cut."

> *"That's freeze and coach. See how it works? You get to stop the clock, think, get input, and try again. In real life, you don't get that luxury. In here, you do. Use it."*

Observer Roles (10 minutes)

> **Facilitator:**
> *"Not everyone will be in the hot seat for every simulation. When you're not the mentor, you're an observer. Observers are not spectators. You have a job."*

Distribute or explain observer roles:

> *"When you're observing, you're watching for specific things. Here are the six categories on the scoring rubric. Each observer will be assigned one or two categories to focus on:"*
>
> ***1. De-escalation:*** *Did the mentor reduce the tension or increase it? What specific moves did they make to bring the temperature down? Body language, tone, distance, pacing.*
>
> ***2. Communication:*** *Was the mentor clear? Assertive? Respectful? Did they use open questions, reflections, affirmations? Or did they lecture, accuse, or talk too much?*

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> ***3. Boundaries:*** *Did the mentor stay in their role? Did they try to be a CO? Did they try to be a friend instead of a mentor? Did they know when something was beyond their scope?*
>
> ***4. Resolution:*** *Did the mentor move toward a workable outcome? Was dignity preserved? Was there an agreement? Or did the situation just fade without resolution?*
>
> ***5. Composure:*** *Did the mentor stay calm? If they lost composure, did they recover? Did their presence ground the situation or add to the chaos?*
>
> ***6. Referral Judgment:*** *Did the mentor recognize when something was beyond their scope? Did they know when to step back and involve staff? Or did they try to handle everything themselves?*
>
> *"During the debrief, I'm going to ask observers to share what they noticed in their assigned category. Be specific. 'I noticed that when the volume went up, the mentor took a step back and lowered his voice. That worked because it broke the escalation pattern.' That kind of feedback helps everyone."*

The Scoring Rubric (10 minutes)

Distribute the Simulation Scoring Rubric.

> **Facilitator:**
>
> *"This is the rubric we'll use to score simulations — not today, and not for the rest of this block. These first simulations are practice. But starting in Week 23, you'll have graded simulation assessments. You need to pass 3 of 5 to advance to Phase 3. So you need to understand this rubric now."*

Walk through each criterion:

> *"Each of the six categories is scored 1 through 4:*
>
> ***1 — Needs Work:*** *You either made the situation worse or you froze and couldn't respond.*
>
> ***2 — Developing:*** *You tried, and some of it worked, but it was inconsistent. You're on the right track but not there yet.*
>
> ***3 — Competent:*** *You handled the situation effectively. Tension went down. Communication was clear. Boundaries were maintained. This is the target.*
>
> ***4 — Exemplary:*** *You handled it at a level that could be used to train others. Not just competent — masterful. This is rare, and it's what you're building toward."*

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Scoring Rubric (Full Detail):

Criteria	1 (Needs Work)	2 (Developing)	3 (Competent)	4 (Exemplary)
De-escalation	Escalated the situation or froze entirely	Attempted de-escalation but was inconsistent — some moves helped, some didn't	Effectively reduced tension through deliberate technique	Masterful — calm, strategic, lowered the temperature for everyone in the room
Communication	Aggressive, passive, or unclear — the message didn't land	Some effective techniques but mixed with unhelpful responses	Clear, assertive, respectful — the person felt heard	Exceptional — empathetic, precise, every word served a purpose
Boundaries	Overstepped role (acted like CO or authority) or had no boundaries at all	Boundaries were unclear — wobbled between roles	Maintained appropriate mentor role throughout	Modeled boundaries so naturally they became invisible
Resolution	No resolution attempted or situation left worse than it started	Partial resolution — some progress but no clear outcome	Reached a workable agreement with dignity preserved	Durable solution that addressed root cause, not just surface conflict
Composure	Lost composure — visibly agitated, reactive, or shut down	Lost composure but recovered — showed self-awareness	Maintained composure throughout, even under pressure	Composed AND grounding — their presence calmed others
Referral Judgment	Failed to refer when the situation clearly required it	Recognized the need but delayed or was unsure how to refer	Recognized the boundary and referred in a timely, appropriate way	Proactive safety awareness — anticipated the need before it became critical

> *"Maximum score: 24. Minimum to pass a graded assessment: 15 — that's an average of 2.5 per category. You need to be solidly between 'developing' and 'competent' across the board.*
>
> *But forget the numbers for now. For the next two weeks, the only thing that matters is practice. Make mistakes. Get coached. Try again. The scores will take care of themselves if you put in the work."*

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Psychological Safety Agreements (10 minutes)

> **Facilitator:**
>
> *"Before we start running simulations next session, we need to agree on something. Simulations require vulnerability. You're going to stand up in front of people you live with and possibly look foolish. That takes guts. And it only works if this room is safe.*
>
> *Here are the simulation agreements. These are non-negotiable:"*
>
> ***1. What happens in simulation stays in simulation.***
>
> *"If someone freezes up, says the wrong thing, or gets flustered — that stays in this room. It does not become a joke in the dorm. It does not get brought up to embarrass someone. Ever. If I find out someone is using simulation performance to mock another participant, that's a Code of Conduct violation."*
>
> ***2. Feedback is coaching, not attacking.***
>
> *"When you give feedback, you're helping someone get better. You're not scoring points. You're not proving you're smarter. Specific, actionable, respectful. 'Here's what I'd try differently' — not 'That was terrible.'"*
>
> ***3. Role-players stay in character.***
>
> *"If you're playing a role, commit to it. Don't go easy on the mentor to be nice, and don't go hard to make them look bad. Play the character as written. The scenario should feel real — not like a setup."*
>
> ***4. Everyone participates.***
>
> *"Over the next two weeks, every person in this room will be in the hot seat. No exceptions. You don't get to be a permanent observer. If you're uncomfortable — good. That's the point. Discomfort is where learning lives."*
>
> ***5. Respect the process.***
>
> *"When a simulation is running, the room is quiet. No side conversations. No laughing at mistakes. Full attention. The person in the hot seat deserves your respect, just like you'll want theirs when it's your turn."*
>
> *"Can everyone commit to these? If you have concerns, raise them now."*

Allow genuine discussion. If someone raises a real concern (e.g., "What if I really can't do this in front of everyone?"), address it honestly:

> *"I hear you. And I'm not going to pretend it's easy. But here's what I know: every single person who's gone through simulation training says the same thing afterward — 'I wish I'd done more of it.' The first one is the hardest. After that, it gets easier. And you'll have coaching every step of the way. You're not alone up there."*

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Preview: Next Session's Simulation (5 minutes)

> **Facilitator:**
>
> *"Next session we run our first full simulation. Here's the setup — I want you to think about it tonight:*
>
> *Two men in the dorm are arguing about a stolen radio. Voices are rising. Other people are gathering. You're a FORGE mentor and you walk into it.*
>
> *That's all I'm telling you. Think about it. What would you do? What skills would you use? What's the first thing you'd say? Don't script it out — just sit with it. Journal anything that comes to mind.*
>
> *See you next session. Get some sleep. Next session we do this for real."*

Closing Circle (5 minutes)

> **Facilitator:**
>
> *"Quick closing round:* ***One word — how are you feeling about starting simulations?****"*

Send the talking piece. Expect words like: nervous, excited, scared, ready, anxious. All of them are correct.

> **Facilitator (closing):**
>
> *"Every word I just heard is the right answer. If you're nervous, that means you care about doing well. If you're excited, that means you're ready to learn. If you're scared, welcome to growth.*
>
> *Next session. Be ready."*

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SESSION 50: Simulation 1 — Property Dispute Escalating to Threats

Duration: 2 hours
Session Number: 50
Facilitator(s): Program Lead + Senior Mentor (if available)

Learning Objectives

By the end of this session, participants will be able to:

1. Apply de-escalation techniques to a dorm conflict in real time
2. Use the FORGE conflict resolution model under pressure
3. Manage a multi-person situation (two disputants plus bystanders)
4. Demonstrate composure when someone challenges their authority
5. Document lessons learned from a simulation experience

Session 50 Checklist

- ☐ Room set up with stage area and observer semicircle
- ☐ Opening circle completed
- ☐ Simulation 1 scenario read and roles assigned
- ☐ First run completed: first attempt, freeze/coach, replay, debrief
- ☐ Complications introduced during replay
- ☐ Lessons learned documented (first run)
- ☐ Second run completed with different mentor and role-players
- ☐ Comparison debrief conducted
- ☐ Lessons learned documented (second run)
- ☐ Closing circle completed
- ☐ Preview of Simulation 2 given (gossip/reputation damage)

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Session Plan

Opening Circle (10 minutes)

> **Facilitator:**
> *"Quick check-in. One sentence: How are you doing and how did you prepare for today?"*

Keep this short. People will be anxious. Acknowledge it.

> **Facilitator:**
> *"Some of you look nervous. Good. That means you take this seriously. Remember — this is practice, not a test. Every mistake is a lesson. Let's get into it."*

Simulation 1 Setup (5 minutes)

> **Facilitator:**
> *"Here's the scenario."*

Read the scene aloud:

> *"It's mid-afternoon. You're walking through the dorm and you hear raised voices coming from the bunk area. Two men — Williams and Carter — are standing face to face. Williams is accusing Carter of stealing his radio from under his bunk while he was at chow. Carter says he doesn't know what Williams is talking about. Williams's voice is getting louder. He says, 'I know it was you. Everybody knows it was you. If I don't get it back by tonight, we're going to have a problem.'*
>
> *Five or six other men are watching. Some are egging it on. One says, 'Handle your business, Williams.' Another is just watching silently.*
>
> *You're a FORGE mentor who lives in this dorm. You walk up. Go."*

Assign roles:

- **Mentor:** First volunteer (or facilitator assigns — spread the opportunities across the group over the two weeks)
- **Williams (accuser):** Senior Mentor or participant. Character brief: You're angry. You're sure Carter took the radio. You've been disrespected. If you don't handle this, you look weak. You're not violent yet, but you're close.

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- **Carter (accused):** Participant. Character brief: You didn't take the radio (or maybe you did — don't reveal it either way). You're defensive. You don't like being accused in front of people. You're not going to back down, but you're not trying to fight either.
- **Bystander 1 (instigator):** Participant. Character brief: You're stirring the pot. "Handle your business." You want to see action.
- **Bystander 2 (silent observer):** Participant. Character brief: You're watching. You're worried. You don't want this to blow up. If the mentor approaches you, you'll cooperate.

Assign observers: Each remaining participant gets one rubric category to focus on.

Simulation 1 Run (27 minutes)

First Attempt (5 minutes):

Start the scene. Let the role-players get into character for 30 seconds before the mentor enters. The mentor walks in and responds.

Facilitator watches for:

- Does the mentor address the bystanders or go straight to the two in conflict?
- What's the mentor's body language? Position? Volume?
- Does the mentor try to separate Williams and Carter?
- Does the mentor acknowledge emotions or go straight to facts?
- Does the mentor get drawn into the content (who took the radio?) or focus on the process (bringing the temperature down)?

Freeze and Feedback (5 minutes):

Call "Freeze" at a natural pivot point — when the mentor is stuck, when the scene is escalating, or at the 5-minute mark.

> *"Freeze. [Mentor's name], don't move. What's going through your head right now?"*

Let the mentor share their internal state.

> *"Observers — what did you notice? Let's go category by category. De-escalation — what did you see?"*

Take brief, specific feedback from observers. Then:

> *"What's one thing you could try differently in the replay?"*

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Pick 1-2 actionable coaching points. Keep it focused — too much feedback is overwhelming.

Replay with Adjustments (5 minutes):

> *"Same scene. Same characters. Take what you just heard and try again. Go."*

Reset the scene. Let the mentor approach it differently.

Complications (introduce one if the mentor handles the initial situation well):

- Carter says: "I don't answer to you. You're not a CO. You're just an inmate with a title."
- Bystander 1 says: "Man, just let them fight. This ain't your problem."
- Williams says: "If I don't get my property back by lockdown, I'm going to handle it myself. You understand what I'm saying?"

Group Debrief (10 minutes):

Everyone sits down. Facilitator leads the debrief.

> **Facilitator:**
> *"Let's break this down. [Mentor's name], you go first — what worked for you and what was hardest?"*

Let the mentor reflect first. Then open to the group.

Key debrief questions:

- What was the first thing the mentor did when they walked up? Why did that matter?
- When Carter challenged the mentor's authority ("You're just an inmate with a title"), how did the mentor respond? What would have been effective?
- The bystanders added pressure. How do you handle the crowd while dealing with the conflict?
- Was resolution realistic in this situation, or was the goal just de-escalation? *(Answer: The immediate goal is de-escalation. Resolution — figuring out what actually happened with the radio — comes later, when emotions are down.)*
- When Williams said he'd "handle it himself" — that's a threat. What's the right response? *(Address it directly: "I hear you. And I want to make sure this gets resolved without anyone catching a charge. Let's figure this out together.")*
- At what point, if any, would you need to involve staff? *(If the threat becomes specific and imminent, or if a weapon is mentioned.)*

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Facilitator synthesis:

> *"Here's what I want everyone to take from this. Property disputes are one of the most common conflicts in a dorm. They look simple — someone's stuff is missing. But they're never really about the stuff. They're about respect. They're about whether someone can take from you without consequences. That's why the emotions run so high. When you intervene, you're not solving a property dispute — you're navigating a respect issue. If you address the respect, the property part usually works itself out."*

Document Lessons Learned (5 minutes)

> **Facilitator:**
> *"Everyone — open your journals. Write a 'Lessons Learned' entry for this simulation. Three questions:*
>
> 1. *What did I observe that worked?*
> 2. *What would I do if I were in the hot seat?*
> 3. *What's one technique or principle I want to remember for real life?"*

Give 5 minutes of quiet writing time.

Second Run: Different Mentor (30 minutes)

> **Facilitator:**
> *"We're running this scenario again with a different mentor. Same setup. Same characters. But different roles — I need new role-players too."*

Assign new mentor, new role-players, and new observer assignments.

Run the full cycle again:

- Scene set (2 min)
- First attempt (5 min)
- Freeze and feedback (5 min)
- Replay (5 min)
- Group debrief (10 min)

Compare approaches: In the debrief, explicitly compare what the two mentors did differently.

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> *"We ran the same scenario twice with two different mentors. What was different? What worked better and why? There's no single right answer — but there are approaches that consistently work better than others. What are they?"*

Document Lessons Learned — Second Run (3 minutes)

Repeat the journal entry for the second run.

Closing Circle (5 minutes)

> **Facilitator:**
> *"Quick closing.* ***What surprised you about today — either about the simulation or about yourself?****"*

Send the talking piece.

> **Facilitator (closing):**
> *"Next session: Simulation 2. Gossip and reputation damage. Someone's been labeled a snitch and they come to you. Think about it tonight — this one has different dynamics than a property dispute. The threat isn't physical yet, but it could become that fast.*
> *Good work today. Every one of you learned something. See you next session."*

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SESSION 51: Simulation 2 — Gossip and Reputation Damage

Duration: 2 hours
Session Number: 51
Facilitator(s): Program Lead + Senior Mentor (if available)

Learning Objectives

By the end of this session, participants will be able to:

1. Assess the safety level of a reputation-based conflict
2. Use MI and active listening when someone is emotionally activated
3. Navigate the social dynamics of gossip and labeling in a correctional environment
4. Determine when a reputation issue becomes a safety concern requiring referral
5. Demonstrate appropriate mentor boundaries when asked to intervene directly

Session 51 Checklist

- ☐ Room set up with stage area and observer semicircle
- ☐ Opening circle completed
- ☐ Pre-simulation discussion on gossip and labels in prison
- ☐ Simulation 2 scenario read and roles assigned
- ☐ First run completed: first attempt, freeze/coach, replay, debrief
- ☐ Complications introduced (Thomas asking mentor not to tell staff, etc.)
- ☐ Safety assessment vs. gossip assessment discussed
- ☐ Boundary discussion: what mentors can and can't do
- ☐ Lessons learned documented (first run)
- ☐ Second run completed with different mentor — Jackson encounter added
- ☐ Comparison debrief conducted
- ☐ Lessons learned documented (second run)
- ☐ Closing circle completed

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☐ Homework assigned (review notes + practice OARS + review conflict model)

Session Plan

Opening Circle (10 minutes)

> **Facilitator:**
> *"Check-in round. How are you doing? And:* ***What did you take from last session's simulation that's still on your mind?****"*

Send the talking piece. Use this to reinforce lessons from Session 50 — people will naturally debrief what they're still processing.

Pre-Simulation Discussion: Gossip, Labels, and Safety (10 minutes)

> **Facilitator:**
> *"Before we run today's scenario, let's talk about why gossip in a prison environment is different from gossip anywhere else.*
>
> *On the outside, gossip is annoying. In here, gossip can be dangerous. Labels like 'snitch,' 'rat,' or 'he's talking to the police' — those aren't just words. Those labels can get someone hurt. Everyone in this room knows that.*
>
> *As a FORGE mentor, you're going to encounter this. Someone will come to you because a rumor is spreading about them. They'll be scared. They'll be angry. And they'll be looking to you for help. The challenge is: you can't control what other people say. You can't go around the dorm demanding people stop talking. But you also can't ignore a situation that could turn violent.*
>
> *Today's simulation is about navigating that space."*

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Simulation 2 Setup (3 minutes)

Read the scene aloud:

> *"A man in your dorm — Thomas — pulls you aside. He's visibly upset but trying to hold it together. He says: 'Someone's been telling people I'm cooperating with staff. That I gave information about the cell search last week. It's not true. I didn't say anything to anybody. But people are looking at me different. A couple guys stopped talking when I walked up. And Jackson — you know Jackson — he said to my face, 'Be careful, people are watching you.' That's a warning. I need to set the record straight before this gets out of hand.'*
>
> *Thomas is scared, but his fear is showing up as anger. He wants to confront whoever started the rumor. He's also considering approaching Jackson directly. He wants your help."*

Assign roles:

- **Mentor:** Volunteer or assigned
- **Thomas:** Participant. Character brief: You're frightened for your safety but you don't want to show fear. You're angry that someone would spread this lie. You want the mentor to fix it — talk to Jackson, find out who started the rumor, clear your name. If the mentor doesn't offer to help directly, you get frustrated: "What good is FORGE if you can't even help me with this?"
- **Observers:** Assigned to rubric categories

Note: This simulation starts as a one-on-one conversation, not a group conflict. The mentor is sitting with Thomas. No bystanders initially.

Simulation 2: First Run (27 minutes)

First Attempt (5 minutes):

The mentor and Thomas are seated, having a conversation. Let it play out.

Facilitator watches for:

- Does the mentor validate Thomas's fear or rush to problem-solving?
- Does the mentor ask open questions to understand the full picture?
- Does the mentor assess the actual safety level (Is this gossip or a credible threat?)
- When Thomas asks the mentor to confront Jackson, does the mentor maintain boundaries?
- Does the mentor recognize that this might need staff involvement?

Freeze and Feedback (5 minutes):

Call "Freeze."

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> *"[Mentor's name] — what are you thinking right now? What's your assessment of the danger level?"*

Let the mentor respond. Then:

> *"Observers — what did you see? Let's focus on communication and boundaries. Thomas asked the mentor to go talk to Jackson. How was that handled?"*

Key coaching points to offer:

- *Validation first:* "Thomas is scared. Before you solve anything, he needs to know you hear him. A reflection like 'This is serious — being labeled like that in here is dangerous, and I understand why you're scared' goes a long way."
- *Assess the threat:* "There's a difference between gossip and a credible threat. Jackson's comment — 'people are watching you' — is ambiguous. Is it a warning from a friend? Or a threat from an enemy? You need more information before you decide how to respond."
- *Boundaries:* "Thomas wants you to be his enforcer. That's not your role. Your role is to support him, help him think through options, and determine if staff needs to be involved. If you go confront Jackson, you're not mentoring — you're inserting yourself into a conflict that could become your conflict."

Replay with Adjustments (5 minutes):

> *"Same scene. Same Thomas. Take what you heard and try again."*

Complications to introduce during replay:

- Thomas says: "You're not going to help me? Then what's the point of this program? I need to handle this myself."
- Thomas says: "Don't tell staff. If staff gets involved, that makes the rumor look true. Then I'm really in danger."
- Thomas asks: "Be honest with me — do you think I'm safe?"

Group Debrief (10 minutes):

> **Facilitator:**
>
> *"Let's talk about this. What makes this scenario different from the property dispute last session?"*

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Key debrief points:

- **Urgency assessment:** Not every gossip situation is a safety emergency. But the "snitch" label in prison can be life-threatening. The mentor needs to assess: Is Thomas in immediate danger? Has anyone made a specific threat? Is there a pattern of escalation?
- **What the mentor can and can't do:** The mentor can listen. The mentor can help Thomas think through options. The mentor can observe the dorm dynamic. The mentor can, if the threat level is high enough, involve staff — even if Thomas doesn't want that. What the mentor cannot do: investigate who started the rumor, confront Jackson, or guarantee Thomas's safety.
- **The hardest moment:** When Thomas says, "Don't tell staff." This is a judgment call. If the mentor genuinely believes Thomas is in danger, the obligation to safety overrides the request for confidentiality. But it should be explained, not done behind Thomas's back: "I hear you, and I respect what you're saying. But if I believe your safety is at risk, I can't stay quiet. That's not about snitching — that's about keeping you alive."
- **MI connection:** This is a situation where OARS are critical. Thomas is activated. He wants action, not conversation. The mentor has to slow it down without dismissing the urgency. "Tell me exactly what's happened, from the beginning" — that open question serves two purposes: it gets information, and it gives Thomas space to organize his thoughts.

Document Lessons Learned (5 minutes)

Journal entry: three questions (same format as Session 50).

Second Run: Different Mentor (30 minutes)

Run the full cycle again with a different mentor and different Thomas.

For the second run, add a layer: After the conversation with Thomas, the mentor encounters Jackson in the common area. Jackson says, unprompted: "Hey, you've been spending a lot of time talking to Thomas. What's that about?"

This tests the mentor's ability to navigate a conversation without revealing confidential information or escalating the situation.

Debrief the second run with comparison to the first.

Document Lessons Learned — Second Run (3 minutes)

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Closing Circle (10 minutes)

> **Facilitator:**
>
> *"Closing round. Two parts:* ***Name one thing you did well or observed that worked today, and name one thing you want to work on before the next simulation.****"*

Send the talking piece.

> **Facilitator (closing):**
>
> *"This week you were introduced to simulations and you ran through two full scenarios. Property disputes and gossip. Both common, both different.*
>
> *Here's what I want you to sit with before next session:*
>
> *Every scenario we run is going to test different skills. Some test de-escalation. Some test MI. Some test boundaries. Some test referral judgment. But ALL of them test one thing:* ***Can you stay composed under pressure and respond with skill instead of instinct?*** *That's the through-line. Whatever else happens, composure is the foundation.*
>
> *Next week we run three more simulations — new arrival being pressured, gambling debt, and racial tension. Each one gets harder. Each one gets more real.*
>
> *Homework:*
>
> 1. ***Review your lessons learned entries*** *from this week. What patterns do you see?*
> 2. ***Practice OARS*** *in at least one real conversation before next session. Journal about it.*
> 3. ***Read the FORGE conflict resolution model*** *one more time. You should be able to recite the five steps without thinking.*
> 4. ***Think about the scenarios coming next week.*** *If a new arrival was being pressured in your dorm, what would you actually do? If you learned about a gambling debt creating tension, how would you handle it? Don't script it — just sit with it.*
>
> *Good week. You did real work. See you next session."*

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